

3.0

Our verbal brand

Our verbal brand shapes how we talk about ourselves, the language we wish to use and the key messages we want to project about Kingston University.

It helps us to communicate clearly with others and helps them to understand who we are and our ambitions.

Our verbal brand includes guidance regarding our name, tone of voice, our brand narrative, key messages and using social media.

3.1

Our name

When naming the University, the correct form is:

Kingston University London

The above form should be used for corporate, international website pages and external profiling at events, exhibitions and recruitment fairs. For these audiences it is important, in the first instance, to use London as there are several places called Kingston around the world and in the UK.

When talking about the University you should refer to it as **Kingston University**, not just Kingston which is a name of a place. We want to establish who and where we are from the start of any dialogue whether online or face-to-face.

Once the University's name has been used in full, '**Kingston University London**', you can revert to using '**Kingston University**' or '**the University**' in the remainder of your communication.

'KU' should not be used on internal or external communications channels or in published documents. It should only be used as an informal shorthand in internal documents. **Kingston University** is the correct form for internal documents, UK media and social media.

When using '**the University**' in a document (once you have used the correct form in full), **there should always be a capital 'U' in 'University'** to signify that you are referring to **Kingston University** and not a generic university.

You may refer to **Kingston University** as an institution in your communications. For example:

Kingston University is the UK's leading university for Future Skills. At the University we want our staff and students to be sought after for their knowledge, skills and ability to innovate.

If you would like support or advice on our house style, please contact: **corporatecommunications@kingston.ac.uk**

3.2

Tone of Voice

The Tone of Voice guidance provides useful information to help you find the right tone for all of your communications.

It is an essential tool to help you to bring the Kingston University brand to life.

We all make speedy, even unconscious, decisions about places, people, products or services based on how things look and how they are described. The **words you choose really matter**. Language has power and can help us to strengthen the University brand and navigate the most challenging situations.

The Tone of Voice (TOV) guidance is designed to help you to reinforce our position as the **UK's leading university for Future Skills**. It will also help you to **bring the brand values to life**. Our brand values are Ambitious, Inclusive, Innovative and Enterprising.

The TOV guidance provides the information you will need to **help you communicate more powerfully and effectively with all audiences** including students, colleagues, stakeholders, opinion-formers, collaborators, the media, partners and investors.

You can also use the TOV guidance when you are commissioning, or briefing others to support Kingston University, including writers, professional services providers, content producers, printers, filmmakers, advisers and agencies.

3.2.1

Using the TOV guidance

It is important to **use the TOV guidance with all audiences**. While the messages you wish to communicate may vary, the **TOV should remain consistent to build trust** in the University and to help you to connect with your key audiences. The starting point for all communications should be:

- who is it for?
- what is the best method for communicating?
e.g. face-to-face, online, filmed content, media / social media, events, exhibitions etc.
- what key messages do I need to communicate?
- are there previous, useful examples from the University that I can adapt for these purposes?

The overall tone you should be aiming to convey is:

Kingston University is a successful, welcoming university that is focused on excellence and is ambitious, inclusive, innovative and enterprising in everything it does.

Kingston
University
London

Our
Values

Ambitious
Inclusive
Innovative
Enterprising

3.2.2 TOV – core attributes

Everything about the University brand links back to the Town House Strategy and our Vision, Mission and Values.

Our Vision is for Kingston University to be sought after by students and staff as a place to further their ambitions and to have a positive impact on our communities.

Our Mission is to enhance students' life chances, support staff ambitions and strengthen Kingston University's impact on industry, policy and the professions to enable a sustainable future socially, economically and environmentally.

Our Values are:

- Ambitious
- Inclusive
- Innovative
- Enterprising

Based on the University's Vision, Mission, Values and reflecting its growing national and international reputation, excellence should be reflected across everything we do.

All communications should seek to reinforce our focus on excellence by ensuring content is well written, accurate and focused on the audience it is seeking to address. Kingston University should always communicate with authority and get the details right.

The Values Framework is a useful source of material when creating new content and will also help you to find and apply the right tone of voice.

The following section is focused on the Kingston University brand values. You can cut and paste any of the content or use this as a prompt to keep your content on brand and reflect the right tone of voice.

Ambitious

We are proud of being part of a high performing culture, where we strive for excellence in everything we do. We set high expectations of ourselves and each other to drive improvement, constantly seeking to be more innovative and enterprising in what we do and how we do it.

At Kingston University we:

- are ambitious for our staff and students
- are focused on the future
- seek opportunities to help our staff and students to become sought after for their knowledge, skills and ability to innovate
- seek collaborations with the world's most successful and ambitious places, organisations, businesses and individuals
- are proud of the University, of our staff, students and alumni

Inclusive

Everyone is valued and respected for who they are and can work and study in an environment that is free from any form of discrimination. Everyone has the right to be included and the responsibility to be inclusive.

At Kingston University we:

- are welcoming and hospitable
- are helpful
- listen with care and respond respectfully
- are generous – always keen to share our knowledge, experience and networks
- use language that is approachable and avoids jargon or unfamiliar technical language
- aim to ensure that all content including social media, video, website, exhibitions and events reflects the diversity of our student and staff population as well of those with whom we collaborate

Aside from times when formal or technical information is required, our communications – whether written or spoken – are clear, warm and relaxed.

Innovative

At Kingston University we are always looking for new ways of thinking and better ways of doing things. We never rest on our laurels. We set ourselves ambitious targets to be ahead of the game, using all the tools available to us.

At Kingston University we:

- aim to ensure that everyone benefits from being in a culture that promotes innovation
- aim to use the most creative channels to get our messages across
- are committed to developing creative problem solving skills and digital competency – this is reflected in the content and materials we produce

Enterprising

We seek out opportunities and transform them into innovative solutions and new ventures that lead to impact, growth, diversification and improvement.

At Kingston University we:

- are motivated to apply our knowledge and resources to explore new and better ways to deliver products and services with partners across the UK and internationally
- are proud of our history and heritage and inspired by our staff and students and the contributions they make to the economy, society and the environment
- are consistently ranked one of top universities in the UK for graduate start-ups and recognised as the UK's leading university for Future Skills, ensuring that students develop the attributes they will need to succeed in life and in their careers
- challenge ourselves to always communicate effectively using appropriate channels, new technologies and techniques to align our events, campaigns with people who share our values

Help and support

More information about the values and how to put the values into action can be found in our **Values Framework**.

3.3

Brand narrative

The brand narrative is the Kingston University story. It is a key resource that can be copied, edited and cut and pasted. Its purpose is to keep the core messages about the University consistent and to save time that would otherwise be spent in creating copy from scratch.

Brand narrative

Kingston University London is an **ambitious institution** with a growing **international reputation** founded on its **transformative Future Skills approach**. This **progressive model of education** is designed to help all **new graduates and our staff to become sought after for their knowledge, skills and ability to innovate**.

Research carried out by Kingston University has informed our Future Skills programme that enables **every student on every undergraduate programme** to acquire the **key graduate attributes** most valued by employers. These essential life skills have been identified as **creative problem solving, digital competency, being enterprising, having a questioning mindset, adaptability, empathy, collaboration, resilience and self-awareness**.

Our **radical new model of education** builds on our reputation as an **enterprising and creative** institution that is inspired by our history stretching back to 1899 and by the **ambition and diversity** of our students.

Through our **Knowledge Exchange and Research Institutes (KERIs)**, we are driving advances in research and knowledge exchange, harnessing our expertise to address societal issues **and growing the impact and visibility of our activity**.

We're proud of our beautiful location in **the historic Royal Borough of Kingston upon Thames** and our close ties with our local communities. With four diverse campus locations, we offer a distinctive experience for students and staff who can enjoy the freedom of a safe, relaxing campus within easy reach of Central London and all its attractions.

Kingston University has a long-standing tradition of **successful collaborations with global brands** such as Adobe, the John Lewis Partnership, Royal Mail, Cisco, IP Group, Coca-Cola, Unilever, Mastercard, J.P. Morgan, TikTok and Barclays. This enables us to continually strengthen our **enterprising and inclusive** ethos with world class organisations as well as with SMEs, investors and partners.

Our ambition is clearly outlined in our **Town House Strategy**, inspired by the University's internationally-acclaimed and **award-winning Town House building**.

The Strategy guides our approach to everything we do including collaborations across the University and with **inspiring businesses, public sector and regional partners**.

We're moving quickly – keeping pace with changes in society and the economy so that we can welcome and **support students and enhance their life chances**.

We are also **supporting our staff ambitions** and strengthening our impact on industry, policy and the professions to **enable a more sustainable future socially, economically and environmentally**.

A downloadable version of the Kingston University brand narrative can be found on the **Brand SharePoint page**.

3.4

Key messages

An important part of Kingston University's brand is the language that is used – including the messages we communicate to support our strategic ambitions. These key messages can be used across all communication channels and all content developed on behalf of the University.

When developing content please select the messages that are most appropriate for the audience you are addressing.

Kingston University is:

1. **The UK's leading university for Future Skills** – enabling every student, on every undergraduate programme, to acquire the **nine key Future Skills identified and most valued by employers**. These essential life skills are: creative problem solving; digital competency; being enterprising; having a questioning mindset; adaptability; empathy; collaboration; resilience and self-awareness
2. Rated **TEF Gold**, one of an **élite group of just 26 higher education providers from across the United Kingdom awarded Gold ratings in all three TEF categories**
3. Respected for its research. Some **70 per cent of our research is rated world leading or internationally excellent** and our knowledge exchange collaborations are helping businesses innovate. We are **growing our impact** through our Knowledge Exchange and Research Institutes (KERIs), concentrated around **our areas of excellence**
4. **Ambitious** – collaborating with **successful global brands** including the John Lewis Partnership, Royal Mail, Cisco, TikTok, IP Group, Coca-Cola, Unilever, Mastercard, J.P. Morgan and Barclays
5. Home to a diverse community with **more than 20,000 students from 140 countries** across the world
6. **Innovative** – driving a **progressive model of education** to help new graduates and staff become **sought after for their knowledge, skills and ability to innovate**
7. **Enterprising** – ranked one of the **top higher education institutions in the UK for graduate start-ups** (source: Higher Education Business and Community Interaction Survey)
8. Home to the **award-winning Kingston University Town House** – a highly original, prizewinning work of architecture that enables quiet reading, loud performance, research and learning to co-exist
9. Playing a pivotal role across its communities and through **partnerships with industry and the public sector**, we are advancing knowledge and **driving economic growth** and impact locally, in the United Kingdom and across the globe
10. Situated in the beautiful **Royal Borough of Kingston upon Thames** with a history stretching back to 1899

Obtain a copy of the key messages at:
Brand SharePoint page.

3.5

Using social media

One way we can all support the Kingston University brand is through social media. Throughout the academic year, there are thousands of opportunities to share what the University is engaged with through an ever-increasing number of social media channels and networks. The University has a team responsible for the institution's profile across key social media channels.

The University has a combined reach of 414,000 across its social media channels. The main channels used are:

1. **Facebook**
2. **Instagram**
3. **LinkedIn**
4. **Threads**
5. **TikTok**
6. **X**
7. **YouTube**

There are links to these channels in this section of the Brand Guidance.

While each channel performs a slightly different function, everyone can link to these channels to follow, like and share information. It's an easy way to find out about events, exhibitions, training and development, graduations – or just checking in to see what colleagues are doing across our four campuses.

When engaging with our social media channels – it's always wise to stop, think, check before you post. Remember the Kingston University values:

- **Ambitious**
- **Inclusive**
- **Innovative**
- **Enterprising**

Try to support these values when you are posting - it all helps to increase the profile of the University, its staff and students and to establish our position as the UK's leading University for Future Skills.

Here are some quick hints and tips to help you stay on track.

Content

Keep it short and informative – you can insert a link to a longer read such as an article, academic paper or presentation

Hashtags #

- If you are attending an event – find out what the official event hashtags are
- Ask yourself what your goals are – who are you trying to connect with by using the #
- Consider using some of our commonly used University hashtags where appropriate. These include:
#FutureSkills
#KingstonUniResearch
#KingstonUni

Visuals

If you are taking photography at an event – make sure that the background of your photo / video content is clear and uncluttered. Check that there is nothing in the background that could be offensive or may include content that is owned by someone else e.g. photography, video content or illustrations. If you have permission to include content remember to credit the originator as required.

Do

- Remember that you are representing the University
- Get it right – make sure the information you share is accurate
- Credit any images or content that you share – always respect copyright
- Seek permission / consent of anyone featured in your posts
- Be truthful and take care with the information you share

Don't

- Be negative – avoid getting drawn in to sharing negative or disrespectful content
- Post excessively – spam can annoy others
- Share every aspect of your life

Take your time. Before posting, check...

- Is my post informative?
- Have I used the relevant hashtags?
- Have I credited the photographer?
- Does this support the University's ambitions?

Section 3.0 - Our verbal brand

Brand Guidance

V.1 March 2025

Social media channels

Channel	Link	Description
	https://www.facebook.com/kingstonuni	Strong platform for sharing info about forthcoming events and exhibitions etc.
	https://www.instagram.com/kingstonuniversity @KingstonUniversity	An important channel for sharing visual content, both photos and short videos.
	https://www.linkedin.com/school/kingston-university	Useful for building your personal profile, networking with others or building new connections.
	@kingstonuniversity	An increasingly important channel for sharing short video content.
	@kingstonuniversity	An emerging platform for sharing news and short-form content.
	https://www.youtube.com/@kingstonuniversity	A platform for sharing staff and student work and info about courses on offer.
 (formerly Twitter)	@KingstonUni	Used mainly for short form news content.
Hashtags	Some useful # #FutureSkills #KingstonUni #KingstonUniResearch	

3.5.1

Favicon



Left: 'K' favicon

The favicon for Kingston University a black box with 'K' reversed out in white.